TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Sociology of Change and Development

What social change is and what drives it, how change differs from development, why societies resist the changes they need — and the non-governmental organisations that have become a third engine of development in Bangladesh.

HUM-2209 · SOCIOLOGY AND HUMAN ECOLOGY · TOPIC 9 · LEVEL 2 TERM 2

1. Social change: definition and marks

Social change is any alteration in the structure, institutions, relationships, values or behaviour patterns of a society over time. It is not mere fashion; it is the transformation of the arrangements within which people live — the shift from joint to nuclear families, from village self-sufficiency to market dependence, from the handloom to the power loom and the automated line (Topic 3 was the greatest case of it).

Its marks: it is **universal** — no society is exempt; **continuous but uneven** — sometimes glacial, sometimes (in revolution or sudden technology) a torrent; **variable in speed and direction** across societies and across sectors of one society — material culture usually changes first, norms lagging (cultural lag, Topic 2); and its **consequences are mixed** — almost every change that liberates someone displaces someone, which is why change is always argued about.

2. Change and development are not the same

Development is change in a *desired direction*: toward greater income and productivity, yes, but also toward health, education, equality of opportunity and dignity — the improvement of the quality of life of a whole population. Change is value-neutral (a society can change for the worse); development is value-loaded: it claims to know what "better" means, and the argument over that claim is the politics of every developing country.

POINT	SOCIAL CHANGE	DEVELOPMENT
Direction	Any direction — forward, backward or sideways	Deliberately toward chosen goals (income, health, education, equity)
Agency	Often unplanned — inventions, contact, accident, drift	Planned and pursued by governments, agencies, communities (Topic 7)

Judgement	Described, not praised or blamed, by the sociologist	Judged a success or failure against its goals
Example	Families shrink as cities grow	A literacy programme raises girls' school completion in a district

Modern measures follow the wider definition: development is assessed not by output alone but by health, schooling and living standards together (as in the Human Development Index), because a richer but sicker and more ignorant society has changed without developing.

3. Factors of social change

- **Physical environment.** Flood, river erosion, drought, earthquake and climate shift force migration, new occupations and new institutions — in the Bengal delta this factor is a standing condition, not an exception.
- **Technology.** The single most restless factor: each invention (steam engine, contraceptive pill, mobile phone, mobile money) rearranges work, family and power. Mobile banking's overnight alteration of how a village saves and pays is a current local illustration.
- **Population.** Growth, decline and migration change the demand for land, jobs and services and the balance between generations (Topic 6).
- **Culture and ideas.** New beliefs — about women's education, about health, about rights — dissolve old arrangements from inside; religious reform and mass literacy campaigns are cultural engines of change.
- **Economy.** New industries and markets create new classes and towns; the garment industry changed the position of Bangladeshi women more in a generation than a century of argument had done.
- **Politics and law.** Legislation (compulsory schooling, labour law, inheritance reform) and political upheaval can force change at a stroke — though law unbacked by custom often changes paper only (Topic 8's culture-based crime).
- **Contact and conflict.** Trade, migration, media and war carry one society's ways into another — diffusion; and conflict, from strikes to revolutions, redraws structures directly.

4. Dynamics: patterns and resistance

The **dynamics** of change — how it actually moves through a society — follow recognisable patterns. Change is rarely smooth: an invention or reform meets resistance, is adapted, spreads by imitation from early adopters to the cautious majority (the diffusion pattern), and finally becomes the new normal that the next change must fight. Thinkers have described the long shape differently — linear progress

(Comte, Spencer), cycles of rise and fall (Spengler, Toynbee), conflict-driven leaps (Marx) — and the honest summary is that societies show stretches of each.

Resistance to change is not simple stubbornness; it has structure:

- **Vested interests** — those whom the present arrangement feeds (moneylenders facing microcredit; hand-process owners facing machinery).
- **Habit and comfort** — the known misery is preferred to the unknown risk.
- **Fear and insecurity** — workers who hear "automation" as "dismissal" are not wrong to worry.
- **Cultural and religious values** — change read as an attack on identity or faith mobilises the deepest resistance of all.
- **Cost and complexity** — the new way may simply demand money, literacy or coordination the community does not yet have.

The practical wisdom of this course's earlier topics applies: change succeeds when it works with felt needs, participation and local leadership (Topic 7), and fails when it is merely delivered at people. Resistance overcome by understanding lasts; resistance crushed by order returns.

5. NGOs in development

A **non-governmental organisation (NGO)** is a private, non-profit, voluntary organisation working for public purposes outside the state — though usually registered with and regulated by it. Bangladesh, where the modern NGO sector was largely born from relief work after the 1971 Liberation War and the 1974 famine, hosts one of the largest NGO sectors in the world, and its leading organisations are studied internationally.

Their roles in development:

- **Microcredit and livelihoods.** Group-based small loans to the poor — above all poor women — pioneered by the Grameen Bank (a specialised bank rather than an NGO, but the model case) and carried worldwide; BRAC's programmes combine credit with skills, markets and graduation support for the ultra-poor.
- **Health.** Community health workers, immunisation support, tuberculosis control, family planning and sanitation delivered door to door, in partnership with and sometimes ahead of state services.
- **Education.** Non-formal primary schools for children the state system missed, especially girls and working children — a BRAC signature.
- **Women's empowerment.** Organising women into groups that bring income, legal awareness (against dowry violence and child marriage — recall Topic 8), and a public voice.
- **Disaster response and climate adaptation.** Cyclone preparedness, relief and rebuilding in a delta that needs it every year; saline-tolerant farming and safe water in the coastal belt.

- **Rights and advocacy.** Legal aid, awareness of entitlements, and pressure on the state to perform its own duties better.

The criticisms are also part of the syllabus answer: dependence on foreign donors and their fashions; accountability upward to funders rather than downward to members; overlap and duplication in favoured districts while others are bare; microcredit's interest burden and the risk of indebtedness it can create; and the argument that NGOs, however efficient, cannot substitute for a capable state — roads, law and macroeconomic policy are not charitable products. The balanced verdict held by most assessments: NGOs in Bangladesh demonstrably reached people the state did not, pioneered methods the world copied, and remain complements to — not replacements for — public authority.

6. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Social change	Alteration over time in a society's structure, institutions, relationships and values.
Development	Planned change in a desired direction — improvement in income, health, education and quality of life.
Diffusion	The spread of cultural items and practices from one society or group to another.
Vested interest	A stake in the existing arrangement that gives a group reason to resist its change.
NGO	A private, non-profit, voluntary organisation working for public purposes outside government.
Microcredit	Very small loans, usually group-based, made to poor borrowers without conventional collateral.

7. Key points and summary

- Social change is universal, uneven and value-neutral; development is the planned, judged pursuit of change for the better — measured by lives improved, not output alone.
- Its engines: environment, technology, population, culture and ideas, economy, law and politics, contact and conflict — usually several at once.
- Change moves by diffusion against structured resistance (vested interests, habit, fear, values, cost); participation is the solvent that makes it stick.
- NGOs — a sector of world importance in Bangladesh — deliver credit, health, education, empowerment and disaster response, pioneer methods, and attract fair criticisms about donors, debt and the limits of substituting for the state.

8. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. A district's income rises 20% in five years while its girls' school completion falls. Has the district changed? Has it developed? Defend both answers.
2. Mobile money reaches a village. Predict its effects through three different factors of change (technology, economy, culture) — one effect each.
3. A factory introduces automated cutting; the senior cutters organise against it. Analyse their resistance under three headings from section 4, then state the Topic 7 remedy.
4. “NGOs cannot replace the state, but the state keeps learning from NGOs.” Explain in five sentences, with one example.
5. Distinguish diffusion from development using the example of fast-food restaurants spreading to Dhaka.
6. State two criticisms of microcredit and the standard reply to each.

Answer key

1. Changed — certainly: its economic structure and incomes have altered markedly. Developed — not on the evidence: development claims improvement in quality of life as a whole, and falling girls' education is deterioration in a core dimension; growth purchased by disinvestment in people is change without balanced development.
2. Technology: payments and records become instant and phone-based. Economy: remittances arrive without middlemen's cuts; savings and small trade become safer and faster. Culture: women and the young gain private control of money, shifting household authority and norms of trust (accept any three well-drawn effects).
3. Vested interest: senior cutters' wages rest on scarce manual skill the machine devalues. Fear: automation reads as dismissal for older workers. Habit/identity: mastery of hand cutting is their pride and status. Remedy (Topic 7): participation — involve the cutters in planning, retrain them as machine operators and quality checkers, and let them lead the transition so the change is theirs, not done to them.
4. NGOs deliver services and pioneer methods at village level with a flexibility bureaucracies rarely match — non-formal schools for drop-out girls began as an NGO experiment. But only the state can make law, run macroeconomic policy, build national infrastructure and guarantee rights to everyone, not just project areas. So governments adopt NGO-proven methods (community health workers, group lending supervision) into public programmes. Each sector does what the other cannot; the learning flows both ways.

5. The spread of fast-food outlets is diffusion: a cultural item transmitted by contact and imitation, direction-neutral as description. It counts as development only if judged to improve lives by chosen criteria — employment created versus health and local trade harmed — which is an evaluation, not a mere spread.
6. Criticism 1: interest rates are high and the poorest fall into debt traps. Reply: rates reflect the real cost of tiny doorstep loans, remain below moneylender rates, and graduation programmes plus savings products address over-indebtedness. Criticism 2: credit alone cannot cure poverty rooted in health, skills and markets. Reply: accepted — which is why the leading programmes bundle credit with training, health and market linkage rather than lending alone.

Texora — course notes prepared from the official syllabus of B.Sc. in Textile Engineering · Made by Sakib